

Ternary form

Ternary form is any musical structure with three separate, identifiable sections. The most common are ABA—or ABA'—and the minuet and trio. Just like binary form, the B section of a ternary form contrasts A in style or tonality.

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◀ 124–125 Degrees of the scale

◀ 154–157 Repeats

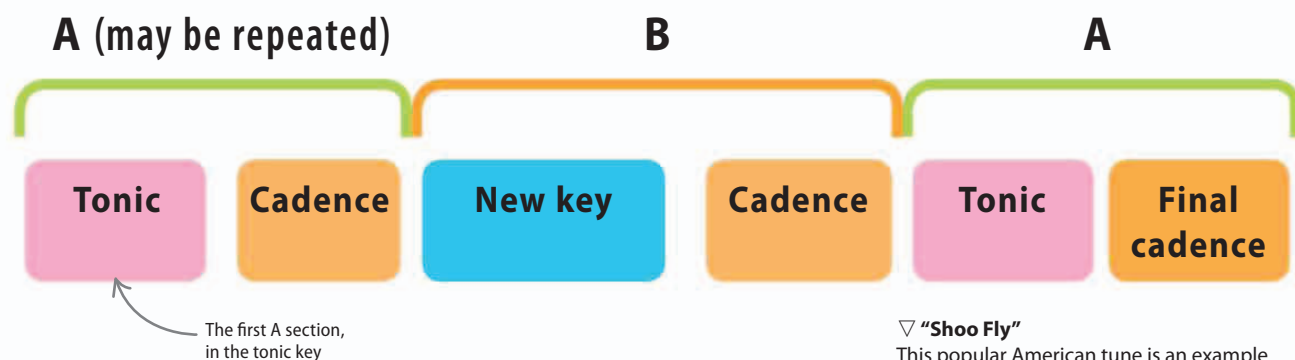
◀ 158–159 Binary form

ABA

In ABA form, a contrasting middle section, B, is “sandwiched” between two identical strains. ABA' (or “A Prime”) denotes a concluding A section—similar to the first A section, but differing slightly. Often the ending of the A' section is written to sound definitively final.

▽ Three sections

The diagram below shows how a ternary piece contains three sections, with nearly identical outer portions. The B section may be in a new key.



▽ “Shoo Fly”

This popular American tune is an example of ABA'. It was first published in 1869 and has been widely recorded and performed as a children's song.



▽ Last phrase of “Shoo Fly”

In this version, the final A section ends with an extended final cadence, with half notes leading from scale degree 3 to 1 (*mi* to *do*).

